SAMPLE

The Man of Two Gardens: The Wealth That Perished

A Close Reading of the Parable of the Two Gardens in the Quran

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Introduction

The parable of the man of two gardens is one of the most vivid and the most sobering in the Quran. It is the story of a man who had everything -- wealth, land, produce, a companion -- and who lost everything in a single moment. The story is told as a parable, not as a historical account. It is a lesson dressed as a narrative, a warning shaped as a story, a truth told through the lives of two men.

The Quran tells the story in Surah al-Kahf (18:32-44), a surah known for its narratives of trial and test. The parable is set alongside the story of the Sleepers of the Cave, the story of Musa and Khidr, and the story of Dhul-Qarnayn. Each story in Surah al-Kahf addresses a different test: the test of faith under persecution, the test of knowledge, the test of power. The parable of the two gardens addresses the test of wealth -- the test that is perhaps the most common and the most dangerous, because wealth is the gift that most easily disguises itself as the proof.

This book is a close reading of the Quranic text on the man of two gardens. It examines the verses, the context, the characters, the dialogue, and the lessons. It asks the questions the Quran itself raises: What is wealth for? What happens to the one who mistakes the gift for the achievement? And what is the meaning of the final verse -- the verse that says that protection and power belong to Allah alone?

The story of the man of two gardens is not an ancient story. It is a mirror. Every age has its version of this man -- the person whose wealth outgrew his wisdom, whose prosperity became his prison, and whose end came not from poverty but from the very abundance he thought would protect him. The Quran tells this story so that we might recognize the man of two gardens in our own age -- and in ourselves, the part that trusts the garden more than the Gardener.

The chapters that follow walk through the Quranic narrative verse by verse, examining the context, the psychology, the language, and the lessons. The goal is not to systematize or to preach -- it is to listen to what the Quran says about this man and the wealth that perished, and to let the text speak. The story is a parable, but the implications are real. The Quran uses this narrative to address the fundamental question of wealth and its purpose, of the gift and its test, of the garden and its Gardener.

The parable is set in Surah al-Kahf, the surah that the Prophet (peace be upon him) recommended for protection against the trials of the end times. The recommendation is not accidental. The surah addresses the four fundamental trials -- faith, wealth, knowledge, and power -- and the parable of the two gardens addresses the trial that is perhaps the most pervasive: the trial of wealth. For wealth is the test that does not feel like a test. Wealth feels like a blessing. Wealth feels like a reward. Wealth feels like a proof. And the feeling is the danger -- because the wealth that feels like a proof is the wealth that becomes the idol. The Quran tells the parable to peel away the feeling and show the reality: the wealth is a test, the gardens are a trial, and the response to the gift determines the destiny of the soul.

Chapter 1: The Setting of the Parable

The parable is introduced with a command:

> "And give them an example -- two men. We made for one of them two gardens of grapes, and We bordered them with date palms, and We placed between them crops." (18:32)

The Quran says "give them an example." The word is *mathal* -- parable, example, likeness. The story is not a historical account. It is a parable -- a constructed narrative designed to teach a lesson. The parable is the method of the Quran when the lesson is not about a specific person but about a universal type. The man of two gardens is not a historical figure. He is a type -- the type of the person whose wealth is the test.

The context is Surah al-Kahf -- the surah of the cave, the surah of the trials. The surah addresses four trials: the trial of faith (the Sleepers), the trial of wealth (the two gardens), the trial of knowledge (Musa and Khidr), and the trial of power (Dhul-Qarnayn). The parable of the two gardens is the trial of wealth -- the trial that every person who has been given abundance faces. The placement is deliberate: wealth is placed alongside faith, knowledge, and power as one of the four fundamental tests of the human.

The parable involves two men. One is given two gardens. The other is given less -- or at least, the Quran does not describe his wealth. The contrast is between the one who has much and the one who has less. The one who has much becomes the focus of the narrative -- his wealth, his attitude, his conversation, his loss. The one who has less becomes the voice of wisdom -- the one who sees what the wealthy man cannot see.

The two men are the two paths. The wealthy man is the path of abundance -- the path that tests the soul with the gift. The companion is the path of wisdom -- the path that sees through the gift to the giver. The two men are not enemies. They are companions -- they talk, they converse, they discuss. But the conversation reveals the difference: the wealthy man sees the gardens as the proof of his greatness. The companion sees the gardens as the gift of the Creator.

The Quran describes the gardens in detail. Two gardens of grapes, bordered with date palms, with crops between them. The description is lush -- the image of abundance, the picture of prosperity. The gardens are not merely functional. They are beautiful. They are productive. They are the ideal of the agricultural wealth -- the wealth that feeds, that sustains, that grows.

The two gardens are the symbol of the double blessing. Not one garden, but two. Not one source of wealth, but two. The doubling is the emphasis -- the emphasis of the abundance, the multiplication of the gift. The man who has two gardens is the man who has more than enough. The two gardens are the measure of the test -- the test that is greater when the gift is greater. The man with one garden might remember the giver. The man with two gardens might forget the giver in the abundance of the gift. The doubling is the test.